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knows the source of problems, too.

"Winter sports are not so popular in India despite the country having the landscapes and potential for development. Basic infrastructure for training and organising competitions is lacking," he adds. Winter games remain an expensive pursuit in India, with most training, competing and coaching done in Europe. With limited domestic facilities and opportunities, parents are reluctant to push their kids into it as a career.

Already 35, Khan perhaps knows that to be there four years later in the French Alps may be a tough summit to reach. He would like the next generation not to worry about funding and focus on performance instead. It's why he seeks to shift his attention to administration and mentoring the next generation of skiers from his base in Gulmarg. He hopes fellow Olympian Shiva Keshavan will join him in this new adventure. "We need guidance from people with experience who can bring plans and projects to fruition. This country has given me so much, I want to give back to it," says Khan. If he succeeds in his quest, then a nation of 1.4 billion can do better than a squad of two on the global winter sports stage. ■

—Suhani Singh

mwork

the history of the Indian men's cricket team

Written in a chatty, informal style, this history will be particularly useful for the IPL generation

C.K. Nayudu's 153 (14 fours, 11 sixes) against a visiting MCC side in 1926-27. Elsewhere, he speaks of Sachin Tendulkar scoring 82 off 49 balls in a one-day international in Auckland and how "the spectators, the opposition and his teammates were joined in the applause by the umpires".

Sometimes, the parallels between the past and the contemporary work well, at other times, they appear overstretched. It is a strength of the book that it is not littered with overwrought opinions and allows the reader to come to her own conclusions.

By fitting the good, the bad and the ugly in about 350 pages without missing anything significant, Prabhudesai has written a book for the reader who wants to trace the evolution of the Indian team without having to dwell on any one aspect for too long or too deeply. ■

—Suresh Menon



SPORTS ◂

Game On

THE 2026 CANDIDATES TOURNAMENT in Cyprus, from March 28 to April 15, will have several Indian chess players in the fray

MEN'S

1. R. Praggnanandhaa
In the last Candidates Praggnanandhaa had two of his compatriots; this time he is the only Indian standing. On current form Pragg appears to be an underdog with favourites including American GMs Hikaru Nakamura and Fabiano Caruana and Uzbek prodigy Javokhir Sindarov.

WOMEN'S

Contrary to men, three Indian GMs will occupy an extremely competitive field. The winner will have the tall order of beating five-time world champion Ju Wenjun.

2. Divya Deshmukh
World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh, at 20, is the youngest of the pack. Making her Candidates debut, the Nagpur native will take on the likes of Russian GMs Aleksandra Goryachkina and Kateryna Lagno, Chinese challengers Tan Zhongyi and Zhu Jiner and Kazakhi Bibisara Assaubayeva.

3. Koneru Humpy
Veteran Humpy makes her third Candidates appearance. A two-time world rapid chess champion and runner-up in the 2011 world championship, Humpy will be hoping to do one better than the 2024 edition, when she finished joint second.

4. Vaishali Rameshbabu
Vaishali makes the Candidates trip with her brother, Praggnanandhaa, for the second straight time. Last time, the 24-year-old had the distinct feat of registering the most number of wins (six) and losses (five). She will be hoping to minimise the latter. ■

—Suhani Singh



MANDAR DEODHAR